

FLOATING CLASSROOMS

XIMB Launches PG Course On A Virtual Platform

Come July and 150 students enrolled into the PCPBM programme offered by the Xavier's Institute Of Management, Bhubaneswar, will log into the Reliance WebWorlds closest to their homes for their lecture. Part of a new e-learning initiative, this virtual classroom platform will offer a real-time multi-way audio and visual presence of the professor and the students.

This one-year programme will be divided into three trimesters and have 300 contact hours. Of these, 240 would be via the virtual classroom format and 60 on campus with direct classroom contact. "This is the first time that such a programme has been taken via video-conferencing to the entire country," said E Abraham, Director, XIMB.

Reliance Infocomm would be providing the latest in broadband and video-conferencing technology with a dedicated 768 kbps line to enable video communication in real-time. This high bandwidth would allow students to make presentations, refer to course materials online, and interact with the professor simultaneously. An added feature would be the recording of every lecture.

This database of lectures would therefore be useful for students for future reference. "This sort of technology provides both the students and the professors with a large amount of flexibility," says Sarup Chowdhury, CEO, Reliance WebWorld. "A student will not miss a class just because he is another city. All he has to do is patch in from the city that he is in."

Currently targeted at executive level students, the total cost of the course is Rs 1.8 lakh. This programme will be followed by another in Rural Management, which will employ the same virtual classroom platform and commence in Oct 2005.

NEW AND IMPROVED

Autodesk Combustion 4 Launched

The Autodesk Media and Entertainment Division (earlier called Discreet) of Autodesk Inc, a leading design and digital media creation, management, and distribution company, launched the Autodesk Combustion 4 software, the upgrade to its visual effects desktop software solution.

With Combustion 4, artists will have access to 3D compositing, comprehensive motion graphics capabilities, numerous filter and particle effects, advanced colour correction, tracking and image stabilisation technology, powerful vector paint, warping and morphing, text effects, simple editing, advanced

animation and expressions, Flash output and more, all from the specially designed, unified and easy-to-use interface.

Version 4 also provides enhanced interoperability with most 3D animation products including Discreet's 3ds Max, cleaner encoding software, and its systems products such as Flint, Flame, Inferno, Fire and Smoke.

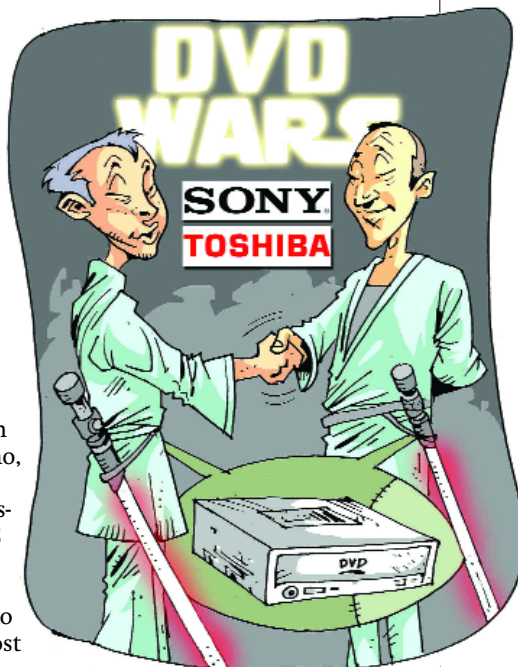
Autodesk Combustion 4 will sell for US \$995 (Rs 42,700 approx); an upgrade from Combustion 3 to Combustion 4 will cost US\$ 249 (Rs 11,000 approximately).

UNITY IS STRENGTH

Sony And Toshiba Want To End Format War

Japanese technology giants Sony and Toshiba are working towards an agreement to develop a new unified standard for next-generation DVDs, after battling three years for separate rival standards.

Sony and Matsushita Electric Industrial introduced the Blu-Ray standard in February 2002 and Toshiba and NEC followed with the HD DVD standard. Both camps were also courting a number of Hollywood studios for support of their format. However reports suggest



that the two camps are working towards reaching an agreement on their joint development.

Nihon Keizai Shimbun, a Japanese daily, popularly known as Nikkei, said Sony and Toshiba stepped up closed-door negotiations in February to find a resolution to their standoff. After reaching a basic agreement that a unified standard would be desirable, they were now looking to develop a hybrid standard that took advantage of each standard's strengths, the newspaper said.

Sony and Toshiba had begun briefing Walt Disney and AOL Time Warner, as well as Hollywood movie studios, to receive their approval for a unified standard and to pave the way for the signing of an official agreement between the rival camps, Nihon Keizai Shimbun said.

360

First it was Yahoo!, offering their Yahoo! 360° service—the regular Geocities-style free Web hosting with the added feature of a blog. Next it was Microsoft, christening the latest Xbox version 'Xbox 360'. We preferred Xbox 2, but since when did we have a say!

We did a Google search for the word '360'

and got 104 million results. Then we did a search for '360 degrees', and got almost 3 million results!

Although it's nice that the biggies are trying to offer 'complete' solutions (thus the term 360), we think they could do with some new blood in their creative departments!

Buzzword
of the MONTH